IT **was as though the world froze, caught mid-step in a game of 'Statue'.** Travel ceased; offices, classrooms, playgrounds, theatres shut down; entire economies ground to a halt. Holding the world hostage for three years was a tiny, spiky creature—500-1,500 times thinner than the human hair, 2,000 times smaller than a dust mote. The novel coronavirus, formally known as SARS-CoV-2, likely sprung up in the wet markets of Wuhan and travelled the world over, unleashing mayhem and the COVID-19 pandemic.

India went into lockdown on March 24, 2020, and, in the next few weeks, decided to look its tiny enemy in the eye. Everything—school, office, hotel, stadium—was turned into a COVID ward. The country masked up, the hand sanitiser became an everyday essential, and a whole new vocabulary entered daily conversation—social distancing, WFH, lockdown, herd immunity, long COVID.

AP



Empty oxygen cylinders being carted for refilling, Delhi, Apr. 23. 2021

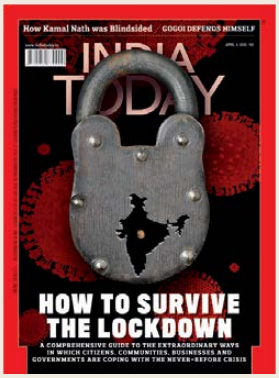


▲ May 10, 2021

COVID exacted a toll not just on lives, but as much on livelihoods. As factories shut shop and supply chains snapped, millions of migrant workers began a desperate reverse journey home. The government announced a Rs 20 lakh crore Aatmanirbhar Bharat package on May 12, 2020, easing credit for the affected sectors, widenining the ambit of performance-linked incentives and a free foodgrain programme.

THREE YEARS THAT CHANGED EVERYTHING

Some of our covers on the pandemic years



▲ Apr. 6, 2020



▲ Jun. 8, 2020



▲ Jul. 20, 2020



▲ Sept. 7, 2020



▲ Apr. 19, 2021



▲ May 31, 2021



▲ Jun. 28, 2021



▲ Jan. 17, 2022